With the Maharaja having already left Srinagar for the relative safety of Jammu,[6] the morale of Srinagar was very low. If the Indian Army had not arrived by 27 October 1947 and taken charge, anything could have happened in the power vacuum. Sheikh Abdullah, who was in New Delhi, confirmed to both Nehru and Mahajan that he supported the accession. This now paved the way for the creation of a power diarchy in the state. On 30 October 1947, the Maharaja appointed Sheikh Abdullah as the Chief Executive Administrator with Mahajan continuing to function as the Prime Minister. Abdullah's long journey that started in 1931, with his political agitation against the autocratic rule of the Maharaja, had now resulted in the Maharaja appointing him the *de facto* Prime Minister of the state. The Maharaja, now having accepted Abdullah as a political representative of the Muslim majority in his truncated and disintegrating state, opened the way for Mountbatten to play his next card. The argument for plebiscite was to ascertain what the public wanted. Given that the overwhelming population of the state was Muslim and a communal conflagration was in progress in the state and in the neighbouring state of Punjab, the apprehension in the minds of both Nehru and Patel was that without Sheikh Abdullah on their side, a single comprehensive plebiscite would tilt the scales towards accession to Pakistan. This would include giving both Jammu and Ladakh, where Muslims were in a minority, to Pakistan. The combined numbers in these two regions would be insufficient to fight the Muslim majorities in the valley, the Poonch belt and the Gilgit Agency. Both Nehru and Patel were unsure if Abdullah wanted to accede to Pakistan. They wanted to be sure that he was on the side of accession to India, so that he could bring in the votes from the valley, the Gilgit and Poonch in a plebiscite. Therefore, it was necessary to both lure and reward Abdullah with political power so that the majority in the state voted for India, if ever a plebiscite was called for.

Mountbatten understood this reality very well and his major contribution to the Maharaja's accession may well have been to formally introduce the requirement for a plebiscite and to persuade both Nehru and Patel of its desirability. This was Mountbatten's answer to the pressure that he was subjected to, by the British deep state, to frustrate the accession of